

POWHATAN'S DISCOURSE OF PEACE AND WAR

Powhatan was a powerful confederation of Indian tribes in the Chesapeake Bay region of present-day Virginia. In the early 1600s, the Powhatan confederacy occupied an area that was roughly one hundred miles on each side. They called the area Tsenacommacah, and it had a precontact population of roughly twenty-five thousand. By 1607, when Captain John Smith arrived with the expedition sent by the Virginia Company of London to establish Jamestown, the population had shrunk by some ten thousand people, largely from diseases borne to Tsenacommacah by previous Europeans. These colonists included a Spanish mission that had been briefly established there in 1571 and the English “lost colony” at Roanoke, which had vanished by 1590. Despite its diminished population, the Powhatan confederacy remained a regional power involved in far-flung trade networks. It included more than thirty tribes, each with its own chief, or werowance. The tribal alliance was held together mainly by marriage and in some cases by coercion.

Powhatan was the adopted name of the paramount chief, or mamanatowick, of the Powhatans at the time of Jamestown's settlement. His given name was Wahunsunacock, and he was the father of Pocahontas. Chief Powhatan was probably in his mid sixties when, in late 1607, he captured Smith and held him for under a month, which was long enough for Smith to learn a great deal about the Powhatans and their leader. (For more on Smith, see the selection of his writings later in this volume.) Smith and Chief Powhatan struck an alliance, and the English and the Powhatans became trading partners. The food and other assistance that the Powhatans supplied to Jamestown allowed the English colony to survive through its first winter, though more than half the men and boys in the small colony died even with their aid, leaving only thirty-eight of the original hundred and forty-four colonists. The metal tools, copper kettles, and glass beads provided by the English enabled the Powhatans to establish trade dominance over inland tribes.

“Powhatan's Discourse of Peace and War” appears in Smith's *General History of Virginia, New England, and the Summer Isles* (1624), as the opening speech in his account of the tense negotiations that led to this trade agreement. In the full text, Smith describes the speech as a “subtle discourse” intended to deceive and manipulate the English, to which he responded with considerable bluster and thinly veiled threats. Probably based at least in part on Smith's memories of these events, the discourse and the entire scene are informed by the conventions of classical historiography, which often features set speeches that distill key elements and add drama to the narrative. As reconstructed by Smith, Powhatan's speech makes a compelling case for peaceful relations, even as questions of its authenticity and sincerity add layers of complexity.

Powhatan's Discourse of Peace and War¹

Captain Smith, you may understand that I having seen the death of all my people thrice, and not any one living of those three generations but my self;²

1. The text is from John Smith, *The Generall Historie of Virginia, New-England, and the Summer Isles: With the Names of the Adventurers, Planters, and Governors from Their First Begin-*

ning, Ano: 1584. To This present 1624 (1624).

2. Powhatan refers to deaths from both disease and warfare.

I know the difference of peace and war better than any in my country. But now I am old and ere long must die, my brethren, namely Opitchapam, Opechancanough, and Kekataugh, my two sisters, and their two daughters, are distinctly each others successors. I wish their experience no less than mine, and your love to them no less than mine to you. But this bruit from Nandsamund,³ that you are come to destroy my country, so much affrighteth all my people as they dare not visit you. What will it avail you to take that by force you may quickly have by love, or to destroy them that provide you food? What can you get by war, when we can hide our provisions and fly to the woods? whereby you must famish by wronging us your friends. And why are you thus jealous of our loves seeing us unarmed, and both do, and are willing still to feed you, with that you cannot get but by our labours? Think you I am so simple, not to know it is better to eat good meat, lie well, and sleep quietly with my women and children, laugh and be merry with you, have copper, hatchets, or what I want being your friend: than be forced to fly from all, to lie cold in the woods, feed upon acorns, roots, and such trash, and be so hunted by you, that I can neither rest, eat, nor sleep; but my tired men must watch, and if a twig but break, every one crieth there commeth Captain Smith: then must I fly I know not whither: and thus with miserable fear, end my miserable life, leaving my pleasures to such youths as you, which through your rash unadvisedness may quickly as miserably end, for want of that, you never know where to find. Let this therefore assure you of our loves, and every year our friendly trade shall furnish you with corn, and now also, if you would come in friendly manner to see us, and not thus with your guns and swords as to invade your foes.

3. Noise or rumor from Nansemond, another tribe of the Chesapeake region.

KING PHILIP'S SPEECH

King Philip was the English name adopted by the Wampanoag leader Metacom (c. 1638–1676), who led an alliance against the English colonies in Massachusetts, Rhode Island, and Connecticut in what became known as King Philip's War (1675–76). Philip was the son of Massassoit, who had maintained peaceful relations with the Plymouth colonists since their arrival in 1620. In 1662, when Philip became the leader of the Wampanoag alliance, longstanding grievances over land and regional governance had transformed the region into a powder keg. War erupted in 1675, after the Plymouth colony executed three Wampanoags. Philip's alliance exacted great costs on the English but was defeated after Philip was killed in the Great Swamp Fight of August 1676.

After the war, there was an outpouring of printed works giving English perspectives on the conflict, most famously the popular captivity narrative of Mary Rowlandson (reprinted later in this volume), which first appeared in 1682 and was republished many times. Rowlandson's descriptions of her interactions with Philip show him to have been in some measure generous and sympathetic toward her, even as he held her prisoner. Other reports on the war were less respectful toward the defeated leader, notably the account of Captain Benjamin Church, whose celebrity as